

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 290

Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

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Section Title(S): TALKING AND TALKS

Bursts of laughter accompany the conversations. Sometimes the !Kung laugh mildly with what we would call a sense of humor about people and events; often they shriek and howl as though laughter were an outlet for tension. They laugh at mishaps that happen to other people, like the lions eating up someone else's meat, and shriek over particularly telling and insulting sexual sallies in the joking relationships. Individual singing of lyrical songs accompanied by the //gwashi, snatches of ritual music, the playing of rhythmical games, or the ritual curing dances occupy the evenings as well, but mostly the evening hours are spent in talk.

521
Conversation

522
Humor

As far as we know, only two general subjects are avoided in conversation. Men and women do not discuss sexual matters openly together except as they make jokes in the joking relationships. The !Kung avoid speaking the names of the gods aloud and do not converse about the gods for fear of attracting their attention and perhaps their displeasure.

521
Conversation

782
Prayers And Sacrifices

831
Sexuality

A talk differs from a conversation or an arranged, purposeful discussion. It flares spontaneously, I believe from stress, when something is going on about which people are seriously concerned and in disagreement. I think that no formalities regulate it. Anyone who has something he wants to say joins in. People take sides and express opinions, accusing and denying, or defending persons involved. I witnessed one such talk only, in 1952. It occurred over a gift-giving episode at the time of N!ai's betrothal and involved persons in Bands 1 and 2, who were settled near together at the time. Khuan//a, the

578
Ingroup Antagonisms

mother of /Gunda, N!ai's betrothed, 291 had diverted a gift—a knife—that people thought was making its way to Gao, the present husband of N!ai's mother. Instead of giving it to him at the time when an exchange of gifts was in order, she gave it to one of her relatives. N!ai's mother's sister, !U, sitting at her own fire, began the talk. She let it be known what she thought of Khuan//a, in a loud voice, a startling contrast to the usual low flow of talk. Di!ai, N!ai's mother, sitting with her shoulder pressed against her sister's, joined in. People went to sit at each other's fires, forming little groups who agreed and supported each other. From where they sat, but not all at once and not in an excited babble, they made their remarks clearly, with quite long pauses between. Some expressed themselves in agreement with !U as she recounted Khuan//a's faults and deviations, past and present. Khuan//a's family and friends, who had moved to sit near her, denied the accusations from time to time, but did not talk as much or as loudly as !U. Khuan//a muttered or was silent. !U said she disapproved of her sister's daughter marrying the son of such a woman but would reconsider her position if Khuan//a gave the expected gift to Gao. The talk lasted about twenty minutes. At that point Khuan//a got up and walked away and the talk subsided to !U's mutterings and others' low conversation. In a few days Khuan//a gave Gao a present, not the gift in question, but one which satisfied Gao, and, as they said, "they all started again in peace."

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